of ingress this void in the establishment has allowed the radicals to make is alarming, even for the security agencies. Especially, when the state has already seen two pro-Khalistan leaders elected to the Lok Sabha in the 2024 general election: Amritpal Singh Sandhu (Khadoor Sahib) and Sarabjeet Singh Khalsa (Faridkot).

With the Bhagwant Mann regime deciding not to extend the detention of Amritpal and his aides under the National Security Act and bring them back to Punjab from the Dibrugarh jail in Assam—where they have been languishing for nearly two years—it may become difficult to keep the Khadoor Sahib MP behind bars for long. His presence will only add to the flux in Sikh politics. Radical factions, including Nihang groups, are already staging protests opposing the SGPC's control over jathedar appointments. They argue that Akal Takht leadership should be chosen by Sikh bodies worldwide, not the SGPC alone. (In fact, the SGPC's influence extends to only the three Takhts in Punjab, the other two being in Patna and Nanded.) How volatile the situation was became evident when Giani Kuldeep Singh Gargaj's installation as the new jathedar of Takht Kesgarh Sahib in Anandpur Sahib had to be advanced and conducted in the early hours of March 10, fearing violent protests. He now also serves as the acting jathedar of the Akal Takht. The radicals, including Damdami Taksal chief Harnam Singh Dhumma, have opposed his appointment and that of Baba Tek Singh Dhanola as the Takht Damdama Sahib jathedar, given their association with Akali politics.

This leadership crisis echoes past turbulence. In early 1999, Akal Takht jathedar Bhai Ranjit Singh and SGPC chief Gurcharan Singh Tohra were sacked in quick succession, and replaced by Giani Puran Singh and Bibi Jagir Kaur, respectively. At the time, Sukhbir's father, Parkash Singh Badal, was both the SAD president and Punjab chief minister. Later, even Jagir Kaur and Puran Singh fell out, and the latter was sacked.

Back then, the Akali Dal's strong influence allowed the institutions to recover. Today, however, the party is grappling with a credibility crisis of its own. Its core Sikh support base has weakened, with voters drifting toward the Congress, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and even the BJP. In terms of seats, the party is left with just one in the Lok Sabha and two in the state assembly. Further complicating matters, senior Akali leaders—Bikram Singh Majithia, Sharanjit Singh Dhillon, Lakhbir Singh Lodhinangal among them—have voiced concerns over the jathedar dismissals, only to be publicly rebuked by the party leadership. This internal rift underscores how deeply divided the Akali Dal has become over the issue.

As Sikh institutions navigate this unprecedented quagmire, calls for structural reforms are growing louder, seen by many as the only way to restore stability and credibility in the panthic leadership. ■



THE SGPC'S MOVE TO DISMISS THREE JATHEDARS HAS LED TO ACCUSATIONS OF VENDETTA POLITICS AS THEY PLAYED A KEY ROLE IN IMPOSING A STRINGENT PUNISHMENT ON EX-AKALI DAL CHIEF SUKHBIR SINGH BADAL

The Samajwadi Party (SP) is in a strange bind in Gujarat. It won two municipalities—Kutiyana and neighbouring Ranavav—in the recent local body polls for 68 municipalities, three taluka panchayats and the Junagadh Municipal Corporation. The trouble is, Kutiyana was won by the party's lone MLA, Kandhal Jadeja, son of late 'Godmother' Santokben Jadeja, the alleged doyenne of illegal mining and several transport businesses in the region in the '80s and '90s, whose life inspired the 1999 Bollywood film *Godmother*, a role Shabana Azmi essayed. The eldest of Santokben's four sons and heir to her dubious legacy, Kandhal has been acquitted in two murder cases but has several other cases under the Arms Act, TADA and criminal conspiracy in various stages of trial and appeal.

His political career had begun with the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), on whose ticket he won the Kutiyana seat in the 2012 Gujarat election, a year after his mother's death. He held the seat for 10 years till 2022, when the NCP denied him a ticket for voting twice against its mandate in the Rajya Sabha polls. And though his history of cross-voting weighed heavy on the SP, it accommodated him, since the recommendation came from none other than Gujarat veteran and former chief minister Shankersinh Vaghela, an old aide of SP founder Mulayam Singh Yadav and whom Akhilesh Yadav often consults. Kandhal himself is believed to have become a Vaghela loyalist in return for a favour Vaghela extended as CM in the late '90s.

Kandhal and the SP make for strange bedfellows. The Akhilesh-led party is a member of the INDIA bloc and has contested elections in concert with the Congress. And it was the BJP that Kandhal cross-voted for in the Rajya Sabha polls while he was with the NCP. But when Kandhal won Kutiyana in December 2022, the SP's cycle was riding to victory in Gujarat after two and a half decades. The last time it did so was in 1998, when Jetha Bharwad, the incumbent deputy speaker of the Gujarat assembly, won Shehra in Panchmahal on an SP